

SMART Goal Setting

By Michelle Whited, Bradley University (IL)

"If you always do what you have always done, then you will always get what you have gotten."

These are not the words that student leaders typically live by. As a student leader, you desire to succeed in all areas of your life, but may struggle in reaching the outcome you envision. Following a simple and effective process for setting goals will help you achieve success in all that you do.

Living the Square of Life

Before we delve into the goal-setting process, you will need to examine different aspects of your life and what you hope to achieve. Think of your life as comprised of four basic quadrants—personal, family, academic and school/community. No quadrant is more important than the other, but thinking this way allows you to compartmentalize your desires and find the area of life that you feel needs the most attention. Jot down those things you want to accomplish in each quadrant and then prioritize.

Examining your life in this manner allows you to see the big picture and plan your goals based not only on priority, but on your own time schedule. You may find you can concentrate on your personal goals when school is not in session or on weekends when your academic schedule lightens up.

The Three P's

When any given person is asked to name successful people, a number of names typically come to mind—Michael Jordan, Oprah Winfrey and Donald Trump, for example. What makes them appear on most people's lists? Besides earning great deals of money, they are leaders in their respective fields. Why? Because they have followed the three P's to reach their goals. They have:

- Set a **PLAN**—At some point in time, they established the steps they would take to get where they wanted to be. And they continue to create new steps as their priorities and goals change or are met. "I approach everything step by step. ... I had always set short-term goals. As I look back, each one of the steps or successes led to the next one" (Jordan, online reference).
- Been **PERSISTENT**—Even when they faced obstacles and setbacks along the way, they have redeveloped their plan or approached a challenge from a different angle to get where they want to be. In the early 1990s, Donald Trump filed for bankruptcy, only to re-emerge to build upon his real estate empire and become host of the hit TV-show, *The Apprentice*.
- Maintained **POSITIVE SELF-IMAGE**—Belief in yourself and visualizing a positive outcome drives successful people. "You become what you believe," says Oprah Winfrey. "You

are where you are today in your life based on everything you have believed? (Carmichael).

SMART Goals

In order to reach the success you want, you need to set SMART goals. When developed correctly, you will have a clear understanding of where you want to go and how you will get there.

- **Specific**—The more specific your goals are, the easier it will be to achieve them. For example, a freshman may walk onto campus and state she wants to be a leader of a student organization. But when faced with more than 200 student organizations from which to choose, this goal doesn't help set a plan to get to the end product. A better way to state the goal is, "I want to be a leader of the Student Government Association."
- **Measurable**—You will need to be able to judge whether or not you have reached your goal. This freshman will need to further develop her goal, as the definition of a leader varies from person to person. In the administration's eyes, she will be seen as a leader just by serving as a representative. In her peer's eyes, she will be seen as a leader by serving as a committee chair. But for herself, those positions are not quite enough. So now her goal becomes, "I want to be president of the Student Government Association."

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- **Attainable**—Whenever you set a goal, you want to make sure it is actually something you can reach and is realistic. The freshman may be so excited to be a part of Student Government and feel she is ready to be president right away, that she plans on running for the position her first year. However, she has struggled academically and is at the cutoff for the required GPA to run for office. While technically she is eligible, she needs to ask herself, at what cost? Her best bet is to spend her sophomore year gaining more experience with the organization and raising her GPA. Her goal now becomes, "I want to be president of the Student Government Association with a 3.4 GPA."
- **Relevant**—Your goals need to be important to you and not someone else. When asked why she wants to be president, the freshman states she has always had a passion for the governmental process and wants to be involved with

an organization that has a direct impact on student life. Obviously, SGA is an appropriate organization to be involved with. If her response had been, "My brother was SGA president at his college and my parents expect me to do the same," then this goal is not hers. The chances of her succeeding are slim to none because she does not have the passion to pursue it.

- **Timely**—All SMART goals have a timeline for you to follow. There is not a set time period for goals. They can be long-range, five to 10 years, or mini—one day to one month. You will find as you develop your goals that you will have many mini and short-range goals that will help you accomplish your long-range goals. The important aspect of the timetable is to include it in your goal statement. The freshman's goal will now be clearly stated as, "I will be president of the Student Government Association when I am a senior with a 3.4 GPA."

Goal-Setting Process

There are many reasons people don't set goals. They have a fear of failure, they don't see the importance of goals or they don't know how. The goal-setting process can be simple and effective if you are willing to spend some time with it. For many students, the idea of goal setting seems daunting and time consuming. However, by setting aside a few minutes every day to address your goals, you will be on the road to success.

- **Analyze your situation**—What do you want to accomplish? What do you hope to achieve? Visualize the end product and work backwards. As the freshman thought about the details of her goal, she saw exactly what position she wanted and under what conditions.
- **State your goal in one sentence**—Keep it short, simple and to the point. Remember, you may set up smaller goals that will assist you in reaching your larger goal.
- **Make a commitment**—Once you set your goal, spend time reviewing it every day. Your goal should always be with you, as everything you do related to this goal should help move you closer to the end result.
- **Make a plan**—This is where your mini and short-range goals come into play. For the freshman, she decided she would serve as a representative her freshman year, a committee chair her sophomore year, vice president her junior year and then reach her goal of president her senior year. In addition, she set academic goals for each semester so she could raise and maintain her GPA to a 3.4.
- **Put it in writing**—This is one of the most crucial steps in the goal-setting process. Put both your goal and plan in writing and review it every day. Hang it where you cannot help but read it—on the bathroom mirror, next to your bed, as the wallpaper on your computer. Review it every morning and evening so you can track your progress.
- **Share it with others**—Share your goal with those people who can assist you in achieving success. For the freshman, she shared it with the current SGA leaders and the advisor. She also let her friends know how and what she wanted to

accomplish because they will support and encourage her to stay on track.

- **Measure your progress**—There are many ways this can be accomplished. One of the easiest is to create a chart or calendar that clearly states what your plan is and the timeline that needs to be followed. The freshman knew she wanted to be a committee chair her sophomore year. So she created a calendar that listed the people she needed to meet with, what those meetings would entail, the knowledge she needed to have to become a chair and the deadlines she needed to meet. By tracking her meetings, she was able to see how she reached her goal. If she had not become committee chair, she would have been able to see where she failed to meet her plan and could then address those challenges in the future.

An Everyday Practice

Whether you realize it or not, you are setting goals every day of your life. Whether you need to get an A on a history paper or you want to be able to run two miles by the end of summer, these are goals you are striving to accomplish. The biggest mistake most of us make is that we are not intentional about setting goals or writing them down. With just a little effort to develop SMART goals, you will be on your way to achieving all that you want and desire. As Yogi Berra once stated, "If you don't know where you are going, you'll end up someplace else" (Berra, online reference.)

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